Adventures of Huckleberry Finn

A simplified retelling

Original story by Mark Twain

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

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1. Escape from a locked cabin

My name is Huckleberry Finn. After Tom Sawyer and I found treasure, the Widow Douglas took me into her home. She wanted to educate me and teach me proper behaviour. I found the rules difficult, but I gradually became used to some of them.

Then my father returned. He wanted my money and disliked seeing me educated. He took me away and kept me in a cabin beside the river. His drinking and violence made the place dangerous.

I found a way out and made it look as though I had been murdered. Then I hid on Jackson’s Island.

There I met Jim, a man enslaved by the widow’s sister, Miss Watson. He had run away after hearing that she intended to sell him, which could separate him from his family permanently.

We were escaping different dangers. For Jim, being caught could mean losing his freedom and any chance of recovering his wife and children.

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2. Down the river

Jim and I hid together until we learned that people were searching the island. We escaped on a raft, travelling mainly at night.

Our plan was to reach Cairo, where the Ohio River joined the Mississippi. From there, Jim hoped to reach free territory. Fog and confusion caused us to miss the turning, carrying us farther south into greater danger.

I had been taught that helping an enslaved person escape was wrong. Sometimes those lessons troubled me more than the obvious cruelty Jim faced. But travelling beside him showed me his care, intelligence and longing for his family.

Once, after the fog separated us, I tricked him into thinking he had imagined it. He told me how frightened he had been for my safety. I was ashamed and apologised. Respecting him required more than enjoying his company when it suited me.

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3. Houses and feuds

A steamboat struck our raft and separated us. I reached the home of the Grangerford family. They welcomed me, and I admired their fine house and polite manners.

But they were involved in a deadly feud with another family, the Shepherdsons. The children inherited the hatred as though it were a household possession. Men carried guns even when attending church.

When a young couple from the two families ran away together, the conflict erupted. My friend Buck Grangerford and others were killed. The respectable appearance of the household had not made its customs sensible or humane.

I escaped and found Jim again. He had recovered the raft and waited for me. Returning to him felt like returning to the safest home I knew.

The river could be dangerous, but on the raft we could sometimes rest without pretending that cruelty became acceptable because a family had practised it for years.

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4. The duke and the king

Two men fleeing trouble joined us. One claimed to be a duke and the other a lost king. I soon understood that they were frauds, but challenging them openly might have made our situation worse.

They used speeches, performances and invented identities to take money from people in riverside towns. Their confidence often mattered more than the quality of their stories.

Their worst scheme involved the Wilks family. They pretended to be the brothers of a recently dead man and tried to steal the inheritance from his nieces.

I could not bear watching the girls trust them. I took the stolen money and hid it in the dead man’s coffin. Then I told Mary Jane Wilks the truth and helped arrange for the deception to be exposed.

The real relatives arrived, and the frauds were nearly caught. Jim and I tried to escape, but the men rejoined us. Doing one brave thing had not removed them from our lives.

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5. A choice I had to make

As their schemes failed, the men became more desperate. One sold information about Jim as a runaway, and Jim was captured by the Phelps family.

I considered writing to Miss Watson and telling her where he was. The rules I had learned called that the proper thing to do. But I remembered Jim looking after me, sharing food and trusting that I would help him.

I tore up the letter.

I believed I might be condemning myself by choosing him. In fact, I was rejecting a terrible rule that society had taught me to call right.

At the Phelps farm, Aunt Sally mistook me for Tom Sawyer, her nephew. I accepted the mistake. Then the real Tom arrived. He agreed to pretend to be his brother Sid while we worked on freeing Jim.

I expected a straightforward rescue. Tom wanted something much more complicated.

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6. A rescue turned into a game

Tom had read adventure stories and wanted Jim’s escape to follow their patterns. He invented unnecessary difficulties, secret messages and dangerous arrangements. Jim and I went along with far too much of it.

Jim was a real person waiting to be free. Tom treated the situation as a story in which inconvenience and danger made the adventure better.

During the escape, Tom was shot in the leg. Jim could have continued towards safety, but refused to abandon him. He helped obtain medical care, knowing that remaining nearby could lead to his own capture.

That is what happened. Jim was brought back in chains. The doctor explained how he had helped Tom, which led some people to treat him better. But his humanity should never have depended on earning their approval through another act of service.

Once Tom recovered enough to speak, he revealed a fact he had withheld from us.

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7. Freedom and its cost

Miss Watson had died and freed Jim in her will. Tom had known this before planning the elaborate escape. The danger he had arranged had never been necessary to obtain Jim’s legal freedom.

Jim also told me that a dead man we had seen earlier in our journey was my father. He had kept me from looking closely because he wanted to spare me the sight.

Tom imagined further adventures. Aunt Sally wanted to take me in and make me respectable. I thought about heading away again before another household began arranging my life.

Jim was legally free, but the journey had shown how easily society denied the humanity of a man I knew to be caring and courageous. My own thinking had not become perfect. Yet the raft had taught me something that respectable rules had often concealed: loyalty to a person could require refusing what everyone around you insisted was proper.

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Words to keep

Enslaved — forced into ownership and unpaid labour by others. Jim escaped while enslaved by Miss Watson.

Feud — a long, bitter conflict between groups or families. The feud caused needless deaths.

Fraud — someone who deceives others for personal gain. The supposed king was a fraud.

Inheritance — property or money passed on after a death. The men tried to steal the nieces’ inheritance.

Conscience — the sense of what is right or wrong. Huck’s conscience had been shaped by unjust beliefs.

Withhold — to keep information or help from someone. Tom withheld the news of Jim’s freedom.

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A question to carry with you

How can a person recognise that a rule they were taught as morally right is actually harming someone?

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